▶ MADHYA PRADESH

A Grain of Irony, Food for Thought

Why is Mohan Yadav abandoning a system that benefited farmers as well as BJP? It's fiscal need

By **Rahul Noronha**

IN A DECISION FRAUGHT WITH POLITICAL RISK, the Mohan Yadav government wants to abandon the decentralised foodgrain procurement Madhya Pradesh has followed since 2007-08. The Centre has yet to move on his request that the Food Corporation of India (FCI) buy foodgrain directly from farmers. The Congress has already tossed the issue into the pressure cooker. So, what exactly is cooking? Why is Yadav giving up on a system with proven efficacy as a vote-getter?

Sources say the reason is financial. MP accounts for 26 per cent of wheat supply to the central pool and 6 per cent rice. In decentralised procurement, the state buys, transports and warehouses the foodgrains till the FCI lifts the stocks. So, over and above its state-level subsidies, MP has to initially bear all the logistics costs incurred by its agencies. That's squared only when the FCI picks up the tab.

But often there's a delay there, due to the time-lag between procurement and central offtake. That creates debt: MP has contracted Rs 7,212 crore as loans since 2007-08, when it moved to this model under then CM Shivraj Singh Chouhan. The interest burden has been bleeding it financially. So, ending that makes fiscal sense. But thrift will also imperil a long spell of robust farm sector growth.

Takeaways

- **MP wants to end system of decentralised procurement**
- **A Chouhan legacy, it bred prosperity on the farms, but was bleeding state fiscally**

THE BOUNTY YEARS

The Chouhan years had seen a nearly 50 per cent jump in gross cropped area. Bonuses on procurement led to a glut of buying centres and warehouses across the countryside. Nor were they too finicky about quality norms. Selling became easier for farmers: they didn't have to queue up for days at distant centres. Farm income growth was nearly double the national average. MP moved out of the hated Bimaru category. 'Mama', as Shivraj is called, became a household name. The BJP reaped dividends in a series of elections. From being a minor player, in one year (2020), MP even upset the champion state, Punjab, with the highest wheat procurement at 12.94 million tonnes. Central procurement may take all that away—in a state where two-thirds of the population is dependent on the primary sector.

What's increased the fiscal strain, though, is another Chouhan legacy: the Laadli Behna payout is now Rs 1,500 per month. A case of one hand taking away what the other gives. ■



▶ KERALA

A FRAU

Mollywood superstar Dileep gets lower court relief in Kerala actress rape case

By **Jeemon Jacob**

AFTER EIGHT YEARS AND 10 MONTHS, Kerala's sensational actress rape case finally saw a verdict. But it wasn't what many expected. On December 8, Honey M. Varghese, principal sessions judge, Ernakulam, acquitted the eighth accused, superstar Dileep (or Gopalakrishnan Padmanabhan), of conspiracy charges while convicting Sunilkumar aka Pulsar Suni and five others for the crime. Dileep was acquitted as the prosecution "could not prove beyond doubt" his role in the sordid case. The state has said